
Oral History in Canada: An Overview

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ORAL HISTORY IN CANADA: AN OVERVIEW

LEO LA CLARE

An overview of oral history in Canada is warranted because oral history here has several distinctive features: there are large numbers of oral history interviews on tape only; most of the creators and collectors of oral history interviews are non-academics; oral history interviews are mainly used in broadcasts and other non-written publications; oral history is extensively used to document non-elite groups; and interviews are conducted in many languages. Are these features different only in degree when compared to oral history elsewhere? Or, are they the result of a distinctive view or concept that Canadians have of oral history?

That large numbers of oral history interviews are preserved only on tape is revealed through a survey conducted by the Canadian Historical Association-Archives Section Committee on Oral History.¹ The Canadian Broadcasting Corporation, the Canadian pioneer in oral history, has the largest collection of oral history interviews, and since it records its interviews for broadcast, the end product is the tape recording. Oral history interviews are also recorded for sound tracks of films produced by the National Film Board of Canada and many private film-makers; for these also, the final product of oral history is the recorded interview. The Public Archives of Canada,² which probably has the second largest oral history collection in Canada, considers the tape recording as the most important oral history document because it is the most complete. It provides a sample of the interviewee's voice, accent, and eloquence, which are often useful pieces of information in describing a person. "But more important, the aural record reveals through intonations, the true meaning of certain statements, which is not revealed in the transcription of the speaker's words."³ Finally, since it is not always possible to prepare transcripts of tape recordings, some creators of oral history interviews accept tapes without transcripts out of necessity rather than choice. Most Canadian practitioners of oral history, however, recognize the need for transcripts because these are the documents used most readily by the academic researcher.

¹*The Canadian Archivist/L'Archiviste Canadien*, "Oral History and Sound Archives in Canada/Histoire Orale et Archives Sonores au Canada," Vol. 2, No. 2 (1971), pp. 52-70.

²*Ibid.*, p. 57.

³*Ibid.*, p. 67.

Most of the creators and collectors of oral history interviews in Canada are non-academics. Interviewers have usually been radio, television, and film producers, undergraduate students, local historians, and community activists; persons who probably prefer to express themselves through oral communications. Many undergraduate students have been supported in their oral history research projects by grants under the Federal government's Opportunities for Youth Program.⁴ Further, a number of historical societies have obtained grants for their oral history projects under the Local Initiatives Program of the federal government.⁵ Senior citizens also have moved into oral history projects and are applying for grants under the federal New Horizons scheme.⁶ Canadian academics, on the other hand, continue to prefer expressing themselves through written communications, and few have applied for Canada Council grants to conduct oral history interviews. One of those few who have applied for and received a Canada Council grant is J. L. Granatstein of the History Department at York University.

Oral history interviews are mainly used in radio and television programs, films, and audio-visual teaching aids. Tape-recorded interviews have also proven useful in promoting classroom discussion. For instance, the History

⁴Canada, Department of the Secretary of State/Secrétariat d'Etat, *Opportunities for Youth: Projects funded by the federal government's Opportunities for Youth program in 1972/Perspectives-Jeunesse: Répertoire des projets subventionnés dans le cadre du programme fédéral Perspectives-Jeunesse en 1972* (Ottawa, 1972).

⁵Canada, Department of Manpower and Immigration/Ministère de la Main-d'oeuvre et Immigration, *Projects by People, The Local Initiatives Program/Quelques réalisations, Programme des Initiatives Locales*, Information Canada (Ottawa, 1972).

⁶Canada, Department of National Health and Welfare/Ministère de la Santé et du Bien-être national, *New Horizons/ Nouveaux Horizons* (Ottawa, 1972), not published.

"The need to record (film, tape, or print) the first-hand experience of older Canadians is one that is being strongly expressed by historians and journalists as well as retired people. Suggestions range from recording pioneer experiences and tracing the development of local communities to reviewing major national and world events through the eyes of those who were affected by them."

"People who have been considering historical research projects stress their potential value to local, provincial and national libraries. They also express the need for sound and video-tape equipment, skilled typists, some travel expenses to archives, etc."

Teachers' Association of Newfoundland and Labrador has put together a commercially available multi-media teaching kit, on Newfoundland fisheries (1900-1930) which includes extracts of interviews with retired fishermen. On occasion, taped interviews have been used in the preparation of theses and articles. For example, a doctoral thesis by David Gustafson about professional regional theatre in Canada⁷ and an article by Donald B. Smith about Grey Owl, a Canadian conservationist,⁸ both utilized tape-recorded interviews. There is, however, little evidence of the use of transcripts. The lack of transcripts and the restrictions on those transcripts that have been prepared may account for this. As more transcripts become available, the use of oral history interviews may increase. It is, however, difficult to predict at this juncture whether the use of transcripts in Canada will outstrip the use of tape recordings, or whether both will be used regularly. It does seem clear that as more academics use oral history, transcripts will get more use.

Oral history has already been used extensively in Canada to document non-elite groups such as labor, cultural or ethnic communities, and pioneers, and this trend seems to be accelerating. One of the reasons for this is that non-academics are most often interested in non-elite groups. In the last few years, some academics have shown research interest in non-elite groups. For example, Dr. Mitsuru Shimo of Waterloo University has recorded interviews with Japanese Canadians. Another reason for the wide use of oral history in the study of non-elites is that the oral technique is particularly well suited. Middle and lower class Canadians have shown themselves to be more at ease with oral communications such as interviews. Moreover, they rarely create or retain large collections of personal papers, and are even less likely to write memoirs. A group of Canadian labor historians have formed a labor history committee within the Canadian Historical Association. Under the direction of labor historians, especially Irving Abella and David Millar of York University, they are conducting oral history interviews with union members.⁹ Surveys of the oral history committee mentioned earlier also disclose that many local historians are interviewing pioneers and settlers. Another group, the Reynoldston Research and

⁷David Gustafson, *The Canadian Regional Theatre Movement* (Michigan State University, 1971).

⁸Donald B. Smith, "Grey Owl," *Ontario History* (September, 1971), pp. 161-176.

⁹See for example, *Canadian Labour History/Histoire Ouvriere Canadienne*, No. 2 (1973). Vanier College CEGEP, Montreal, P.Q., Canada 379.

Study Committee, is specializing in interviewing members of cultural communities in British Columbia.¹⁰ Many cultural communities, and academics interested in their history, have received grants from the federal government's multi-cultural program to conduct interviews. Although there are a number of completed and on-going projects with elite groups such as national politicians, psychologists, and theatre directors, these have not set the tone or pattern for oral history in Canada and have not been conducted on the scale of the Columbia University or the Presidential Library projects in the United States.

Because there are two founding peoples and two official languages in Canada, there are oral history projects in both English and French. Not surprisingly, almost all oral history interviews in French were recorded in Quebec. There are not, however, many instances in which the same topic is documented through interviews in both languages. I know of only one such collection; the interviewer, an anglophone, found it easier to elicit responses from his French-speaking interviewees by conducting interviews with them in French. With growing numbers of projects on cultural communities, there are more and more interviews being conducted in languages other than English or French. For example, Dr. Shimo's interviews with Japanese Canadians were for the most part conducted in Japanese. Several interviewers, whose mother tongue or working language may not be that of the interviewee, find that they obtain better information by using the interviewee's mother tongue. The oral history interview lends itself well to the use of a second language by the interviewer or interviewee, because the use of a second language is easier in oral communication. However, these interviews will be difficult to transcribe. Not very many persons are at the same time fluent in a language other than English and French, and able to type. There are additional difficulties in obtaining typewriters with the alphabet of languages other than English and French. Translating the taped interviews into English or French, and then preparing transcripts of the translation is at least equally difficult. In view of these problems, it seems likely that such interviews will remain untranscribed. Of course, the tape recordings themselves are very valuable because the manner in which the language is spoken may be just as important to researchers as the information about events and people.

The great emphasis on the tape recording is perhaps

¹⁰ Reynoldston Research and Studies/Recherches et Etudes Reynoldston, *Publication*, Vol. 1, No. 1 (Vancouver, 1972).

the distinguishing feature of oral history in Canada. The transcript is a by-product or a version of the oral history interview. Is this the Canadian concept of oral history? Is it because of this concept that oral history in Canada is usually associated with, and at times integrated with, historical sound recordings of speeches, talks, conferences, radio programs, and folklore? This association is quite evident from the survey of the Canadian Historical Association-Archives Section's Committee on Oral History.¹¹ The vagueness of the term "oral history" most certainly confuses the concepts or views that are held. The uninitiated often believe that the term refers to all historical records in oral form. Perhaps the concept of oral history as primarily an oral record is not solely a Canadian concept but common elsewhere as well.

¹¹*The Canadian Archivist/L'Archiviste Canadien*, "Oral History and Sound Archives in Canada/Histoire Orale et Archives Sonores au Canada," Vol. 2, No. 2 (1971), pp. 52-70.